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BUILDING ON SUCCESS, CALIFORNIA STRENGTHENS ITS FLAGSHIP VIOLENCE INTERVENTION PROGRAM AS DEMAND REACHES ALL-TIME HIGH

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SACRAMENTO, Calif., Sept. 26 -- The California State Assembly Democratic Caucus issued the following news release:

SACRAMENTO, CA -With California's homicide rate at its lowest point in recorded history, California Governor Gavin Newsom took a key step in furthering public safety by signing Assembly Bill (AB) 2378, a bill authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), which establishes an Office of Community Violence Intervention (CVI). This law expands and strengthens the California Violence Intervention and Prevention (CalVIP) Grant Program - the very initiative credited with helping drive that drop in crime. As applications for CalVIP funding continue to pour in at record levels, AB 2378 gives the program the senior-level leadership it needs to keep pace and keep saving lives, using the dedicated funding source established by historic legislation authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, theCalifornia Gun Violence Prevention and School Safety Act of 2023.

"California has become a national leader in reducing gun violence because we've made a sustained commitment to investing in smart, proven strategies to stop violence before it occurs," saidAssemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), co-founder of California's Gun Violence Working Group. "AB 2378 builds on that leadership by creating a dedicated Office of Community Violence Intervention to strengthen and coordinate this lifesaving work across our state. I'm grateful to Governor Newsom for signing this important legislation and for his continued leadership in protecting our communities."

The numbers tell the story of a state whose approach to public safety is working. Studies show that California's homicide rate fell to 3.5 per 100,000 residents in 2025, the lowest rate recorded since the state began tracking crime statistics in 1966. Homicides dropped 18.6 percent and the statewide violent crime rate fell 10.2 percent in a single year. Community violence intervention programs like CalVIP, which put trusted messengers directly into neighborhoods most affected by gun violence, have been central to that progress.

Under the Director's leadership, the Office of CVI will administer the CalVIP program more effectively, coordinate with the Department of Justice's Office of Gun Violence Prevention, engage in long-term strategic planning, share best practices, evaluate grant implementation, and provide technical support to applicants and grantees.

Why AB 2378 Matters

In 2019, Governor Newsom signed theBreak the Cycle of Violence Act, codifying the CalVIP Grant Program. In 2023, he signed the historicCalifornia Gun Violence Prevention and School Safety Act, authored by Assemblymember Gabriel, establishing a permanent, dedicated funding source for CalVIP.

The impact has been significant: communities that received CalVIP funding saw homicides decrease nearly three times more than those that did not. In 2024, California recorded its lowest gun homicide rate in state history, driven by sharp reductions in violence among the young people the program is designed to reach. Given this success, demand for CalVIP has surged. During the most recent application cycle, requests for funding topped $1 billion. AB 2378 expands and strengthens critical violence intervention work across California and helps ensure the state's investment keeps producing results.

AB 2378 was backed by a broad coalition of gun violence prevention advocates, cities, and community-based organizations, including sponsor GIFFORDS, Everytown for Gun Safety, Moms Demand Action, Students Demand Action, and Brady California, along with several others - reflecting diverse perspectives.

What Community Leaders Are Saying

"From Oakland to Los Angeles, California is seeing record-low rates of gun violence. These aren't just impressive numbers - these are real lives being saved. With the formation of a statewide office of community violence intervention, we will be able to expand and improve on this critical work, creating stronger, healthier communities. Consistent funding through CalVIP is the backbone of gun violence prevention work in our state. By creating this new office, we can ensure that funding is being awarded and distributed by people with firsthand experience, and that every dollar goes toward saving lives."- Mike McLively, Policy Director at GIFFORDS Center for Violence Intervention

"Community violence intervention programs are a critical part of the work to prevent gun violence and save lives in communities across California, and they deserve strong, coordinated support. AB 2378 will help ensure California's investments in this lifesaving work are strategic, sustainable, and informed by what works on the ground. We're grateful to Assemblymember Gabriel for his continued leadership."- Alex Navarro, Volunteer with the California Chapter of Moms Demand Action

(News Release; Media Release; Announcement; Press Briefing; Remarks; Congressional Documents; Court Order; Court Judgement; Judgment; Court Opinion; Federal Government; Local Government; State Government; Speech; Transcript, Notice, Notification)

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